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Dan Morgenstern

Dan Morgenstern is one of the nation's most respected jazz historians. He served as the director of the Institute of Jazz Studies at Rutgers from 1976-2010, and is a recipient of a Jazz Master Award from the National Endowment for the Arts. Dan was the editor of DownBeat *magazine from 1964-1973, and has received eight Grammy awards for his liner note writing.*

Dan was interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 9, 2013 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in the jazz archive at Hamilton College. It's a privilege to have Dan Morgenstern with me today. And I just picked up a little thing from another interview you did, which puts you right with most other jazz musicians when you said, "Morning is not necessarily the best time for me." So here we are in the morning. Anyway, welcome to Hamilton.

DM: Thank you. It's real pleasure to be here, and I'm so glad that I finally got to see your lair here, which is wonderful. I love all the photos. They're different. It's not the standard issue stuff. And it's really fun what you've been doing here.

MR: Well coming from you I appreciate that a lot. And I got to visit your lair a couple of times and I was pretty blown away by all that. It's so interesting that the route jazz has traveled from what essentially was sort of a folk music, a popular music, to now being considered a very high art form.

DM: Yes, it's quite a sea change. And of course there are still, although the ranks are dwindling, but there are musicians around who very well remember the days when it was — an audience that took jazz seriously was definitely a minority. And for most people it was something to dance to, it was something to have fun to.

MR: Was there a point in jazz history, what point in jazz history do you think that really turned around?

DM: Well early on I think the first people who started really taking — aside from the musicians themselves — that started taking it seriously, strangely enough, were the people, a bunch of them at Ivy League colleges who started collecting jazz records and would go out of their way to find what was then known as race records, which wasn't a pejorative. "Race" was a term that was used by the NAACP, you know they talked about race, and so when Clarence Williams and Perry Bradford, who were really the pioneers, they were the pioneers in starting this branch of ethnic recording. There was precedent, because record labels like Columbia had a whole ethnic series, they were making Greek

would be frequented by the particular minority. So it was not anything, there was nothing negative about it, it was just the record companies wanting to find a market to sell things. But these people, there were people at Princeton and there was — Marshall Stearns was the founder of the Institute of Jazz Studies, at Harvard. You know they started going out to find these recordings by people like, oh, Bessie Smith and of course the Armstrong Hot Five and all, which very quickly entered the recording mainstream actually. But they were the first to — and there were people in Europe also. Robert Goffin, who was the first to write a respectable book that attempted to trace the history of the music, in 1932, two years before the much more famous Panassie. So late twenties is about when this begins. And at the Institute of Jazz Studies we have a bunch of correspondence that came from a man who is not terribly well known, because he didn't do much in the way of writing or anything, but he was — when he was in college he was a very good pianist and he sat in with the Wolverines and knew Bix [Beiderbecke] and everything. And the people who early on tried to find out about jazz, like Charles Edward Smith, who was one of the pioneer jazz writers in this country, wrote an article called "Collecting Hot" for *Esquire* magazine, I think it was 1933. There is correspondence there where this man knew things about King Oliver and about Bix Beiderbecke and so on. And I'm trying to think of his name. It's a senior moment. It will come back to me. But there are letters that these people wrote to him. And they were really fishing in the dark. Because there wasn't anyplace, you couldn't really go anywhere. You had to go to the musicians themselves and ask them. But there was often a question of their being accessible. And King Oliver, who was being discovered on the strength of his wonderful recordings by the Creole Jazz Band had by then, by 1930, he was off the beaten path. He was working with a band mostly down south touring in the backwoods. And his career had really gone down. So it was hard to find him to ask him. So this was all being pieced together. When Marshall Stearns decided — he was an English Lit guy, you know that's how he made his living, he got his Ph.D. It was a Chaucer specialist from Yale. But he discovered his thesis topic, and this was an obscure Scottish poet named Robert Henderson, and he is writing a little note to somebody and he says, "I found my topic," and gives this guy's name and he says nobody knows anything about him, just like jazz.

MR: Well you mentioning Europe — and I'm only partly familiar with your story of when you were a young boy. Did you hear jazz in Austria?

DM: Well Austria, which is where I started out, what I heard of jazz was pretty much limited, as I can tell in retrospect, from records. I liked to — my mother had a wind-up phonograph and I liked to play around with that and also her mother, my mother was one of four siblings, she was the oldest but she had two sisters and the brother. And my

bought that in 1912 to raise her family. I spent my summers there as a kid. And there were a bunch of records that belonged to my mother and her siblings, and there was dance music. But it really turns out in retrospect to have been the closest thing to real jazz was by a British trumpet player named Nat Gonella. He was an Armstrong acolyte when Louis first came to Europe — he came to England in 1932 — Nat was one of the first to welcome him and took him under his wing and got him settled in London and all that. He was an absolute Louis — but he had an original quality. He had a strange embouchure like Wild Bill Davis out the side of his mouth. Made tons of records, hundreds of records, in the thirties. They were big sellers, not only in England but in Scandinavia where he visited, and in Germany where they still had — under the Nazis they were not too good at deciding what was jazz and what wasn't. They banned it, but the records were still available until World War II broke out, then they started clamping down. But anyway, this record by Nat Gonella, his theme song was "Georgia on my Mind." And he sings and plays very much in a Louis manner. So that was probably the first thing with me. The other things were pretty — there were some Paul Whiteman records and stuff like that. But then, after leaving Austria courtesy of Hitler when he marched in on March 12, 1938, I got out eventually. My mother's father was Danish. So she was Danish born when she married my father, there was no dual citizenship. But because she had been born a Dane, she and I were able to get into Denmark.

MR: You were about nine years old?

DM: I was eight when Hitler took over Austria. I was nine, and fairly recent in Copenhagen when my mother, bless her, decided that I might enjoy a Fats Waller concert. Fats was touring Scandinavia, and she got tickets for Fats Waller in 1938, in the fall of 1938, and that was my first, you know, real, that was Fats Waller. You know he was doing a single. He started out, the concert opened with him jamming with some Danish musicians and then they left and he took over by himself. I didn't have much English then, but his energy, his eyebrows going up and down, the way he looked into the audience with his feet pumping, and the rhythm of it you know and great piano playing. It was really quite wonderful. And I won't say that I became a jazz convert overnight, but naturally I wanted to get Fats Waller records and stuff like that. I had started — I had a bunch of records already so —

MR: Can you recall, as an 8-year-old, understanding why you had to leave the country?

DM: Oh yes. I understood that. I mean I didn't understand it on a very highly sophisticated level, but I absolutely knew — we still didn't know at that time — that was before the Holocaust really, it was before — 1942 was really when that really evil stuff — but it was bad enough as it was. I remember even before, when I was about six or so, one of my

everybody of a certain age there, he was forced into doing stuff for the government. And he was actually in a kind of labor gang, not full time, but they were working on building the famous Autobahn. And he had to wear a kind of uniform thing with a swastika armband. And I remember him arriving at my grandmother's and tearing off this thing and throwing it in a corner and saying, you know, as if it was something dirty. He left very soon after. He wanted my aunt to come with him. He went to Australia. He immigrated to Australia. So he was a non-Jewish — he was an Arian anti-Nazi. And there was conversation, you know, pretty constant, about what the Nazis represented. My father was a writer. He had been a Viennese cultural correspondent for a major German newspaper in Frankfurt, which actually was started by my great-great grandfather. And so once the Nazis took over the paper was Jewish-owned, but, you know, they were stripped of it and my father lost his job. My father had been born in what was then the Austria Hungarian Empire, but later, after World War I became Poland, now it's Ukraine, you know, it's right on the border there. But my father was born actually not even in what they call a shtetl, which is like a little village, but he was born in the country, out in the country. But he was born into a religious Jewish family. They were Hasidm, so he was raised that way. And then of course he went to Vienna to study and he became a cosmopolitan so to speak. He was a great music lover. He had played cello as a young man in his school orchestra. He actually became the first cellist. But he'd given that up. But he became a close friend of Alban Berg so I remember Berg, who died when I was just six years old. But I remember him well because he was a close friend, and sometimes my father and he would take me to — well they were soccer fans and would go to soccer games.

MR: Can I ask you about a word you used when you were describing your father's family, they were religious, and you used a word — Hasidm?

DM: Hasidm. Well they're the kind of really seriously religious, wear the curls and the hats and so on. But my father, my grandfather, my paternal grandfather was very — unlike most Hasidm are very insular, he was aware of the fact, he said to my father, "If you want to make your way in the world you have to learn," you know, "you have to know German, you have to be educated in the Western Civilization" so to speak. So he allowed — which was unusual — he allowed my father to go to what they called a gymnasium, which is like kind of overlapping late high school, early college, you know, the educational system is somewhat different there. And he allowed my father to go to Vienna and get his — actually he insisted that he study law, because he wanted him to get into something more suspect. My grandfather died very early in my father's life, my father was in his teens still when he was killed in an accident that involved a runaway

owned a lot of the land around this little village where my father was born. So he was an unusual person in this kind of environment. Most other Jewish families were much more, as I say, much more insular. But he was already somebody who himself had stepped out of that kind of restrictive environment and become part of the overall — so my father was very conscious of being Jewish. He was very much aware of what was going on with Hitler, and even in Austria there was — every Nazi party in Austria, and there were Austrian fascists. There was this guy named Dollfuss who was assassinated in 1934 who was kind of — he didn't like Hitler, he didn't like the Nazis, but he was supported by Mussolini actually, but he was very antisocial democrat. There was almost a civil war in Vienna in 1934 with shooting and killing and stuff. Everything was shaky.

MR: Yeah. And I wonder, did some of your extended family, aunts, uncles, etcetera, not take advantage of the opportunity to get out at that time?

DM: Most of my father's — his sister, his youngest brother was killed in World War I, he was a soldier. He was an Austrian soldier and he was killed by the Russians on the Russian front. He had another brother and two sisters. And his mother, of course, after my grandfather had died, was still there. When the war broke out, World War I that is, my father went and got them all out of there because it was very near the Russian border, and they were afraid of the Russians. Because the Russians were noted for pogroms against Jews. Not all of them, but the Cossacks — and so it was a dangerous situation. So he went back and got them, brought them all, they all settled in Vienna. So they were initially, they were not captured when World War II broke out, but, but, unfortunately some got away to Czechoslovakia, some of my relatives, and eventually made their way to what was then Palestine. But my father's one sister and one brother and his mother were all victims of the holocaust.

MR: And you yourself had a — I guess after going to Denmark there was an underground system?

DM: Yeah. Well actually, this is April 9th is not? It is April 9th today? April 9th was the day that the Germans occupied Denmark. April 9, 1940. I remember it very well because it was the second time in my life that Nazis marched into a city that I was living in. When I was in Vienna I had scarlet fever at the time of the Anschluss. But I remember, that was considered a serious illness then, and that was one reason why my mother stayed with me and my father had to get out in a hurry. So he split and went to France. That's a whole other story. But I remember the yelling and screaming. The Viennese, they would like to forget about that now, but the majority welcomed Hitler. And I remember that noise from everybody screaming "Heil." And then on April 9th, 1940 I was asleep. My bedroom had sort of a slanted window. We were living on the top floor of a building in Copenhagen

good place for a painter, for a studio, because there was plenty of light. And when I woke up I heard planes and I looked out and I could see the German — that cross that they had on their wings there, and then the swastika on the tail. So that was the Germans coming into Denmark, which was not a happy awakening. The planes dropped leaflets that the Germans had come to protect Denmark against the British and whatever. Anyway, it was interesting because the early part of the occupation, the Germans needed Denmark as a larder. Denmark was a major producer and exporter of foods — dairy products and pork especially, bacon and eggs, butter, milk and everything. And the Germans could use all that stuff. So they called Denmark, they called it, that was like their window to the world that they could behave themselves, which they did for a while. But in spite of that there were all kinds of things that happened which the Danes did not relish and the underground developed gradually and also the Germans started behaving differently. But in 1943, in the fall of 1943, they decided to round up all the Jews in Denmark. It wasn't a very large population but the underground was prepared for that, and they had managed to obtain the list that the Germans had of who they were going to arrest. And so, I mean I don't really want to get — I want to talk about jazz I guess, but what happened was at 4 o'clock in the afternoon one day, it was in September I guess, or early October, before my birthday, knocked on the door, opened the door and there was this nice young man who said, "May I come in I have something important to talk to you about." And he gave my mother and I instructions, detailed instructions, about what to do, where to go, don't pack anything except maybe an overnight thing, don't tell anybody, we will inform people, don't worry about what's in your apartment, just get out and meet at a certain place. And then we met there with other people and they gave us some money for travel and told us what tickets to get on a train — the whole thing was very well organized. As it happened the first attempt did fail and then there was about a period of almost a week when I was planted at different people's homes overnight and stuff, and then we got out to Sweden, which there's this narrow body of water between Denmark and Sweden. And the Swedes, who were neutral, accepted both Norwegian and Danish — Norway was also occupied by Germans — refugees. And so I came to Sweden in October of '43 and spent a year and a half until the war ended in Sweden, and then went back to Denmark. And my father in the meantime had adventures in France where he was interned by the French and eventually the French turned that internment camp over to the Germans, but he managed to get away and made his way to Vichy, was in Marseilles, was assisted by this great American named — what was his name — Varian Fry — he was a civilian. He didn't have any — the State Department was very ambiguous about helping Jewish refugees, it was limited what they would accept. But he went to Marseilles and he managed to get a

something that you could buy. He went to Morocco, and from Morocco to Lisbon. And he had long ago applied for an American visa because of all the things that happened. But once he got to Portugal he was able to get a, you know, entry, a permit to the United States and got out in April of '41. And that was before Pearl Harbor, so we were still, we were in Denmark. In all the time that he was roaming around in France and Morocco and so on it was not — it would not have been a good idea for him to write to us because the Germans censored all the mail that came from overseas from other countries. But once he arrived here he was able to communicate with us and we knew that he was okay.

MR: God, that must have been quite an event when you finally got a letter from him.

DM: So since he came here in '41 he became a citizen after five years, in '46, and then he was able to get my mother and I to come here in '47. So I arrived in the U.S.A. in April, April 21st, 1947.

MR: Well I appreciate you telling me that saga. I find it extremely interesting.

DM: Well the Danes were marvelous you know. They did all this, obviously taking great risks, as if it were the most natural thing to do. They got almost everybody out. The people who didn't get out mostly made mistakes and didn't follow instructions and that's why they were caught.

MR: Okay. Well I'm going to — in the time I have then I'm going to leapfrog ahead, but only a little bit. Because I wanted to ask you about young Dan goes to Harlem. And I had heard a radio interview that you did, about going up to Harlem and checking out the music and stuff. I wonder what — can you describe like what a night would be like?

DM: Well this was not too terribly long after I came to New York and I had met this little underground trumpet player named Matt Lorber, nickname was "Face"; he knew everybody and everybody knew him, and also met a very hip young lady who was the first to take me to the Apollo Theater in Harlem, and that actually turned out to be a night when Dizzy's big band was appearing there with Chano Pozo, so I got to see that, which was tremendous. The Apollo was — one thing of course — the Apollo was frequented to some extent by, you know, there was always a number of white people in the audience. And what I heard when I first came to New York, because my father knew that I was a jazz fan and all that, but people were saying it's risky to go to Harlem, don't go to Harlem at night and all that. But when you were with musicians it was no problem at all. So, you know, going to places, Harlem never was — although you have the famous Minton's, you have the Savoy which had a tremendous history during the big band era in terms of jazz. But it wasn't really — years later when I came to Chicago, when I was with *DownBeat*, I went into Chicago's south side, which was the black neighborhood, there was a lot more jazz activity there than there really was in Harlem. But there were

going, but it wasn't what it used to be. But there were little clubs and there was this wonderful trumpet player and singer named Hot Lips Page. Lips was my friend, Nat was a kind of protégé of Lips'. Lips was from Texas and he didn't call him "Face" but he called him "Shorty" which was pronounced "Shouty" — that was his Texas accent. And going to Harlem, Lips lived there, was a wonderful experience. There were after hours places, and the after hours places could be somebody's apartment where there was an old upright piano and a refrigerator full of ice and cold beer and bottles of whiskey, and you paid something at the door and then you paid for what you drank. And musicians would come in and play, it would be like a jam session. And there were also — there was a place right near Minton's actually, which was the basement of a hotel, the Braddock I guess, which was an after hours place, but it was like a fully equipped nightclub. But it didn't start until 3:30, 4 in the morning, which was after the clubs closed. And then there was a so-called social clubs which also had permission to operate after hours and had liquor licenses and there you would, there was, when you came in there was a desk and you would become a member, you could join, you'd get a membership card. I remember one night going to a place like that with Lips. And it was downstairs. Of course you came in and you got your membership and went downstairs. And they had food and drink. They served — chicken in the basket was a big thing in Harlem — that and ribs. Tremendous. There was a place where they had the best potato salad I ever had in my life. It was great. But anyway, the music, well there was a piano there, and at the piano, it must have been my lucky night because at the piano was none other than Art Tatum. I've written about that, but I think Tatum was at the piano, on the floor sitting at his feet was Charlie Shavers, the great trumpet player and a terrific — what a great guy Charlie was. And Joe Bushkin. And I remember Art was playing. And you know Art wasn't totally blind. He had peripheral vision. Actually he was a very good pinochle player. Roy Eldridge, who was very friendly with Art, told me that he would hold his cards in a certain way so he would be able to see them. And Roy said he was hot, he was a good pinochle player, you couldn't take advantage of him. But anyway he'd kind of look down at the two guys sitting at his feet and he said to Charlie Shavers, he said, "Any note you play I'll play figure eights around it."

MR: That's great.

DM: And at one of the tables, eating some chicken, was Billie Holiday. So I mean Harlem could be, that wasn't something that happened every night. And there were also places, like Lips knew all these places. There were places that were really like, they called them "buckets of blood," neighborhood joints frequented by working class people that were pretty rough. I remember one had a turnstile at the bar so that you couldn't get out before

MR: Very creative.

DM: That was called the Locust Club. But they had a little bandstand and they had a guy there that was a pretty good tenor player, but he was noted for falling asleep on the bandstand sometimes late in the evening. And Lips was a great jam session guy. You know, that was — he was loved everywhere he went. So if you were with Lips you were welcome anywhere.

MR: I see. The social club then was integrated?

DM: To an extent yes. I mean, but the white people, you would see them there, like Joe Bushkin, would be musicians or people who were pretty hip. Like I think with Joe was Johnny DeVries, who was a sometime lyricist. He wrote lyrics to some songs and was friendly with Eddie Condon and that bunch. Lips would play — Eddie Condon's had jam sessions like on Tuesday nights, not Mondays, but Tuesdays, and Lips was very often a guest there. Condon's was one of the few places in the village that was — the band was integrated, they had Edmond Hall on clarinet. And it was a pretty hip place, Condon's. Condon was a wonderful, wonderful guy.

MR: Well you must have been on your way to becoming pretty hip yourself, even maybe you didn't even realize it.

DM: I had no thoughts at that time of becoming in any way professionally involved in the music, but I was — it was like 52nd Street was in its final stages, but it was still alive and it was no small thing to have Sidney Bechet at Jimmy Ryan's and across the street maybe Charlie Parker if you were lucky and he was in town. And, you know, Billie Holiday at the Onyx Club. So there was still a lot going on. And this was, you know, still a vibrant time. There was downtown on weekends, there was the Stuyvesant Casino in the Central Plaza, where these guys, Bob Maltz and Jack Crystal, who is Billy Crystal's father, they booked musicians that were available for relatively little. Because this was the time when bebop had come in and a lot of swing era musicians were not that well employed. You know guys with big names — you had Buck Clayton, you had Roy Eldridge, you had Hot Lips Page, you even had Coleman Hawkins once in a while, you had Sidney Bechet certainly, you had a whole bunch of people. And that was a buck and a quarter, and it was what they called a "beer racket" insofar as beer was about the only beverage that you could buy there, but you bought pitchers of beer, and there was dancing. And a lot of the customers were young kids from Brooklyn and the Bronx who liked to go dancing and also to go pick up girls; and you know, girls would come to pick up guys. There is a short film called "Jazz Dance" that was shot at the Central Plaza that gives you some of the flavor there. Willie "The Lion" Smith is in it and Jimmy McPartland. Bands were great. So anyway I was hooked on this stuff but I still did not have any — I wanted to be a

not much more than a glorified messenger but I got to meet a lot of people and actually was talked into running for office at the American Newspaper Guild, a pretty left wing thing. I was a Wallace — Henry Wallace was running for president. That was that famous election when Truman — Truman and Dewey. And it was a great experience because I was working at Time Inc. I was at a nerve center there on election night, which was a studio where they were broadcasting, and there was a guy named H.V. Kaltenborn, who was — he was something similar to the people they now have on Fox News now. You know, he was a real right winger and of course a great Dewey supporter. And as the news came in it was just amazing what was happening there, because nobody could believe it when it came in that Truman was winning. And Kaltenborn, who had a kind of complexion, he turned red as a beet. I thought he was going to have a heart attack or something. There was quite a way to — it was a great education for American politics. But anyway, then my father had become very friendly with the great cartoonist Al Hirschfeld, who had a circle of, you know, friends, a lot of the *New York Times* people. So my father, who had been, also been a theater critic and became friendly with Brooks Atkinson, who was the *New York Times* first string drama critic, and he used to take my father to openings because he said my father was the only person he knew who would not ask him at intermission, "Well what do you think," you know, which is a terrible thing when somebody does not want that. So they became great friends. At first it got me a job as copy boy at the *New York Times*, which I didn't realize then was a pretty big deal, you know, that's very coveted. But at the time I'd been there about three months I got drafted. So when I got drafted my father was very nervous. Of course he had not been happy about my hanging out late at night, you know, sometimes even not coming home at all. Anyway he thought that I would not be fit for Army duty. But it was all right, so that was a kind of a sea change. And then when I came out I went on the GI bill, I went to Brandeis University. And even then I had no thoughts about getting into jazz in any kind of professional way, but I started — eventually I became editor of the school paper called *The Justice*, and there was a little — Brandeis was very new then. It started, and the first class was the class of, let's see, '52. And there were only about — all undergrads, no graduate school then, about 700 students, a wonderful faculty, and there was some money for student activities but a very few jazz fans got together and decided to get some money to bring jazz to campus. So we hooked up with George Wein who then was running Storyville. This was before Newport, just before, just at the cusp of Newport, actually the year Newport started — '54. So we went to George and asked if we could ask some people who were appearing at Storyville to come to Brandeis. He said, "You can do it, get anybody you want. If they want to come you can talk to them, but it has to be on a

downstairs called Mahogany Hall, which was the traditional club, and upstairs was Storyville, and on Sunday afternoons both bands would play. And then at the end there would be some get-together. So the most remarkable thing that involved that kind of a Sunday afternoon was when Art Tatum's trio was upstairs and Sidney Bechet was downstairs. And for the jam they got together and played as Sidney sat in with the Tatum trio, and they played "Lady Be Good" and that was a [gestures]. This was on the occasion — that was also the real coup. We brought Stan Getz — he had Brookmeyer — we brought them to campus And that was very nice but there was no — I became friendly with Stan later, much later. But it was very, you know, it was kind of impersonal. They came, they played, they played very well, the students liked it, but that was in and out. But then we wanted to get Tatum, and I really wanted Tatum without the trio. I wanted him to do a solo. And we went to talk to him and he immediately said yes. And so we were able to bring Tatum. Brandeis is about 16 miles out of Boston, you know, it's in Waltham, it's easy to get to. And we got the best piano on campus and got it tuned to a tee and everything. We picked him up in Boston and drove him to campus and he played a marvelous concert. One of the people who showed up was Machito, who happened to be somewhere in the area and he found out about it.

MR: The percussionist?

DM: The leader of that great Latin band, which you know Charlie Parker recorded with them and everybody. Frank Grillo was his real name. And all the classical people at — Brandeis had a pretty heavy classical faculty with some fairly well known composers — and they all came to see Tatum. And he played a marvelous concert. *DownBeat* had a correspondent then, Nat Hentoff had left already, and that was Dom Cerulli. He reviewed it for *DownBeat* actually. This was in 1955, the year before Tatum died. And this was, you know, in order to get people to come to these things I would write something in the paper about them, and that was really my first jazz writing. And then when we drove Tatum back to Boston I was sitting with him in the back and my friends were driving. And I said to him, you know, I thanked him. And he said, "I should thank you," he said, "because" — and this totally overwhelmed me — he said, "this is the first time I've played a solo concert all by myself." Meaning that he had done solo concerts before but it was always on some kind of double bill. He might be the opening act and then there would be something. You know Normal Granz was his manager for a while, I mean he booked him during the Jazz at the Philharmonic days, so there were things like that. Or he would appear in concert with his trio. But he said this was the first time he had done — so that completely floored me. And that's when I sort of started — not right away, but it started me thinking about trying to do something for this music. Because there was a

genius like that and he was not adequately recognized. Tatum died a year later. He died in '56.

MR: Amazing. Now that's a great AHA moment sort of. And I had them myself along the way here when the first couple of times some veteran musicians that I was interviewing would ask me about coming to the campus to play. In a sense they were trying to get a gig. And I remember thinking wow, this person here who's had a long career, you make these assumptions like they must be doing great, they probably can stop working if they want. Definitely not the case. But I wanted to ask you about the writing of liner notes. What kind of parameters — first of all you're hired by the record label usually?

DM: Yeah. Usually — I mean my career as a liner notes writer began when my friend Don Schlitten, who was a noted producer, he was then with Prestige, and he asked me to do notes. See I went — after I got out of Brandeis I was at the *New York Post*, I was an editorial assistant in the so-called drama department, which was music, film and so on. I got to write one thing that was the first thing that was ever printed of mine actually, was a review of a Randall's Island festival night in the *New York Post*. But then I eventually left there when I was offered the job at *Metronome*. That's when I became a full-fledged jazz writer. Before that I had started writing for a British magazine, *Jazz Journal*. I wrote them a monthly news column. Anyway, Don asked me to do notes for a not particularly glamorous enterprise. It was an album by Willis Jackson, the tenor player, and it was called "Neapolitan Nights." The program was all Italian-derived tunes, okay. So that was kind of neat to write about because I had to link this up with jazz and the history of that, you know "Come Back to Sorrento" by Vido Musso, you know. But that was the beginning. And Jesus, I couldn't have made a living on this because Prestige at the time was paying 35 bucks for liner notes. This was in 1962. So it was a little more than it is now, and Prestige was one of the lower paying labels. So I did a bunch of stuff for Don, most of it of a more elevated, artistic nature than "Neapolitan Nights," reissues, and — especially reissues. That became my first specialty sort of. And Don was doing a series of stuff — masters that they had leased from other labels. So that was the beginning, and then when "Metronome" folded very quickly I had the dubious distinction of being the last editor of "Metronome." But it didn't fold because of anything that we'd done wrong. Actually it was a very good magazine if I may say so. But the publisher had it as a tax write-off from his business. He had an electronic services company. This was 1961, in the relatively early days of things like computers and so on. So electronic servicing was a fairly new enterprise. And he was doing fairly well at it. But what happened then was that his biggest client, I forget who they were, said that either you become exclusively ours or we will take our business elsewhere. So he was forced to become, rather than an

changed his tax picture so he could no longer write the magazine off. And that's when he came to us and said — because he was an ex-musician. He had been a tenor and clarinet player in the twenties, and he actually — I found out, I made a correction to Brian Rust's famous Discography because he was listed as unknown in the personnel, to a very obscure band called Dunk Rendleman and his Alabamians that recorded for Gennett in 1926 or something. But I was able to tell Brian that the gentleman named Robert Asen was the unknown clarinet and tenor. So he, you know, he was a nice guy and he really had a feeling for the music and everything, but he had to close the magazine down. And then the next thing for me after collecting unemployment and translating Joe Baron's jazz book, that was a welcome little thing there. Bob Thiele, the noted producer, mostly known for his association with John Coltrane of course, it started — he had a magazine when he was a kid. He was a rich kid. His father had Baker's Chocolate, and he started a magazine called *Jazz* in 1941 and then it folded in 1942 because I think he was drafted into the Coast Guard. That's when he had already started *Signature*. He was like a wunderkind deal. But then he got the yen to start a magazine again, but because he was working for *Impulse* he didn't want his name associated with it. And I became the first unpaid editor of this magazine called *Jazz*, which eventually became "Jazz and Pop," but that was after I had left. But he paid me off in liner notes and they paid better. They paid 75 bucks rather than 30 something.

MR: Did you ever have to write — did you ever take on an assignment to write liner notes for music that you really didn't care for?

DM: Not really. I did have – I mean since I was not — except for that brief period when I was with *Jazz* magazine — maybe you could say that I depended on it as a main source of income for me, but I could afford to say no. I mean no, I didn't want to write about anything that I didn't care for. Why? I mean you would try to sell somebody a bill of goods. Honestly, there may be music that was very good in and of itself but I just had no particular connection with it and no particular feeling for it, I would turn it down.

MR: And sometimes they must have given you different — like some liner notes there's comments about each individual song, and some of it's more of a general thing. Did you have to tailor your writing to what the record label wanted?

DM: You know you never got — at least I didn't — you never got specific instructions. Notes are almost always assigned by the producer except for some big labels like RCA and Columbia when there was somebody hired to — but the smaller labels weren't that stratified. But they had a public relations office. Bob Altschuler at Columbia would assign liner notes. And at RCA they also had people. But usually it was the producer. And you would not get very specific instructions because after a while people figured that

changed completely when LPs became CDs. Because the CDs were much smaller format, but not only that but they were sealed and the notes were inside in the booklet. So in the LP era you knew that your notes were on the back of the album and that people would go to record stores and they would read the liner notes before they bought the record. I mean in some cases if there was the latest Miles Davis, you know, you didn't have to. So you were in a sense, you knew that you had an obligation to make the product appealing. But in any case, if you were writing the notes and you liked the music you didn't have to try to cook up some kind of phony sales pitch. The music would really speak for itself. But I found out — and there was somebody after the talk yesterday who said that — I've run into literally dozens and dozens and dozens of people who come up to me. And it was a little startling to me — by now I'm 83 years old you know, but this started when I was maybe in my sixties and some guy who was like maybe in his forties, you know, would come up to me and say, "When I was a kid I would read you," or "I was reading you in *DownBeat*" or whatever. But often they said they would browse through records in the store and that my liner notes were some things that would cause them to buy a particular album.

MR: Yeah, of course.

DM: So you try to make — but most of all I think the obligation of the liner notes' writer is to try to enhance the listening experience for the listener. And so I think one thing that's important is to identify soloists when they're not obvious, mostly when it comes to a band performance. Or if there are two people playing the same instrument or whatever, and to point out certain things that might be helpful. And again I found that people have told me that this was indeed so, I mean that they learned something from — and my biggest fans actually for a long time in the days when there were many more jazz DJs than there are now, I sometimes would get notes and things from DJs saying how much they appreciated that I, unlike a lot of other liner note writers, I would say something about each cut on the album and I would say things like who was soloing, and also what the tempo was if something was a ballad or an uptempo thing or whatever. Because they said very often they didn't have time — a new record would come in and they wouldn't have time to listen to all of it and this way —

MR: It helped inform their choices of what to play, yeah, sure. It made them sound more informed.

DM: And actually, one of the reasons why I did that, although I didn't start initially, was that I've done quite a lot of radio over time. I started out at WBAI in New York. And Gunther Schuller and Martin Williams had a program called "The Scope of Jazz." And Martin had to bow out and he turned it over to me. And so, that was back in the sixties. Nat Hentoff

like a series, one hour jazz, a Sunday night broadcast. But then once I got with the Institute we started, when WBGO was the new jazz radio station in Newark back thirty-some years ago, they came to us at the Institute and asked us to do a weekly program, and we decided to call it "Jazz from the Archives." And so Ed Berger and Vincent Pelote and I and some of the other people who worked for us would take turns doing the program. We started out, the station didn't have very much. They had no record library. We of course had a huge library. So early days we were three hours a week and then later it was back to two and now for the last 15 years or so it's been a one hour show. But anyway, I've done a lot of radio. Nat's very useful when you play records on the air, to be able to look at a liner note and see what it says about the tune and so on. Anyway the liner notes, when I was still at Rutgers the very nice library director Lynn Mullins who was a great fan of the Institute's, and she wanted a bibliography of my liner notes. And at that time my younger son Josh was still in school, actually he was — well he got his B.A. from the University of Chicago but then he went to law school first to Brooklyn College and then Columbia. But he had some time in the summer so he put this thing together. But I couldn't even remember all the notes that I did, and it adds up to hundreds and hundreds, something like 700.

MR: No kidding. And of the Grammys you received, would you have said yes, that was some of my best work?

DM: Well, as I usually would say when I got these Grammys, it's no great — it's due to the great musicians that I was able to write about and the great music that I was able to write about. My Grammys are notes for — I think for Art Tatum, for Louis Armstrong, for Fats Waller, for Erroll Garner, for Clifford Brown. Hey. You know.

MR: Right. That's a heck of a good start. I wanted to ask you about — I guess this would be sort of a current question. I've had some conversations recently with a professor about women in jazz. And I wonder if you have any thoughts about the question of why isn't there more?

DM: Well it's a good question, I'm glad you asked it, because it is something that is on my mind. We know that historically there've been certain important women in jazz — certainly the singers, but then there's Mary Lou Williams who is always brought up as the great female arranger, composer and instrumentalist. But although there were some very talented women, a lot of piano players but also horn players, it really was a minority. I remember seeing — Charlie Shavers brought a group into a little club in New York called Lou Tarasi's which was a special trumpet place. The owner loved trumpet players. He booked Roy Eldridge, he booked Charlie Shavers, he booked Buck Clayton, Bobby Hackett, Billy Butterfield. And this was in the forties still. And there was a female bass

attractive lady. And she played great bass. But that was such a novelty. And today fortunately we have a lot more talented and fairly prominent women in jazz. I mean I was a big fan of hers anyway but I was very happy when Anat Cohen started winning the clarinet thing in the *DownBeat* Critics Poll and has won it over a number of years. She also came very close to being musician of the year. She was like second a few years ago. But there are others. Ingrid Jensen is a very good trumpet player, Virginia Mayhew is an excellent tenor player, and they have groups that are otherwise male in most cases, so women have also — Anat has a quartet and they're all guys except her. So this is a very welcome thing. Because I remember in the days when I was a judge at collegiate jazz festivals, usually if there was a girl in the band, in the big band, she would have the baritone chair.

MR: Interesting.

DM: I mean that was it. And that wasn't fair. Once in a while there would be somebody maybe in the trumpet section. And in the late sixties, early seventies, when was it, there was this really good lead trumpet player women, I think she's still around. She eventually got some studio work and stuff. And she was a great lead trumpet player. And then you had Diva. That's where I first heard Anat actually. She was one of the best people in that band. But it was really a hell of a band. It still is very good. I haven't seen them in a while, but they could hold their own with quite a number of all male bands. They're really a terrific band both in terms of section playing and soloing and so on. So women are becoming more recognized, as they are in general in the whole wide world. I mean now we have — suddenly we have business executives who are women. And if you watch television, which I do more now that I'm retired, although I am not a couch potato yet, but I do watch more. Like daytime TV, which I never watched before, it's astonishing how many women there are on television as anchors, as reporters. Actually they outnumber the men. And they're very good. They're also good in things like reporting on the stock market like Maria Bartiromo and all these people, they're very prominent. So women are definitely becoming more and more — and it's true also in our environment in colleges and universities. Not only are there more female students, they are now pretty much the majority, but also faculty members and department chairs and so on. It used to be really dominated by men. So in the music too. There's a really — have you hear Bria Skonberg yet?

MR: I've seen her picture.

DM: Yeah. She's cute. She's from British Columbia.

MR: Right. As a matter of fact I did see her, I almost forgot, at the Jazz Educator's conference in Atlanta in January she was there.

DM: She's very good. And she is surprisingly, and it matters that way too, they can play anything. I mean she knows Louis backwards. There's a band in New York that plays every Wednesday afternoon at Birdland from 5:30 to 7:15. It's run by David Ostwald who is a lawyer who plays tuba, and it's an Armstrong-dedicated band. It's called the Gully Low Jazz Band. It's a Louis Armstrong memorial jazz band. So they play all Louis repertoire. But Bria, she knows all the stuff, you know, she can do a terrific job on the cadenza to "West End Blues" you know. But even beyond that, I heard her a couple of weeks ago and she did "Cornet Chop Suey" and did it backwards. And then she can do very contemporary stuff. She writes songs and lyrics. She sings. She's a very good singer. And it's really nice to see. And Anat, can do that too. She plays with Ostwald too when she's in town. She's quite busy, you know, touring and stuff. And she can do the traditional clarinet stuff and then she can go outside too.

MR: Let me check my camera here, and also check the time.

DM: The time is twelve minutes after eleven so we're cool as far as the train goes.

MR: I'm not sure what's going on —

DM: Can we start over again?

MR: I was curious if you think there's a reason that women were sort of on the outside in jazz for so many years.

DM: Well it would be several things. I mean one may be the question of attitude, you know, male superiority or whatever. The other may have been to some extent a practical matter. You know during the big band era the only women who were really involved were the singers and the singer usually had to hook up with one of the guys in the band, either marry them or be the girlfriend of, in order to be protected from the usual male stuff. So that was another reason maybe why even if there was, or had been, a really talented and competitive female instrumentalist, there would have been a reluctance on the part of the band leader to hire her because of the potential difficulties. And then also you know, with being on the road, okay, so the guys, you can sleep on the bus, if you check into a hotel room you double up. There were problems, practical problems. But maybe also there were not so many women I think who wanted to enter this whole field which (a) was competitive, (b) was not — except for people like us — highly regarded by members of the family, or whatever. But it was mainly, it's a little similar to what happened in terms of integration acceptance. You know jazz people were pioneers in being accepting of African-Americans. It was really the first public arena in which there was integration to some noticeable extent. And in terms of what was going on behind the scenes among musicians of course there was a notable absence of prejudice because after all most of the white musicians in jazz were inspired originally by a black performer. So it's logical. But

there was a shortage of women who were prepared to really cope with all these obstacles. Woody Herman had a very good trumpet player named Billie Rogers who was in the band during World War II, and that was one moment where there was a little bit of that. You would suddenly find some female musicians in the sections of a big band. I think Lionel Hampton had a girl tenor player. There were isolated instances of that, and that's because so many guys were getting drafted and there was a shortage of competent players. But what we have now, and this is a gradual process, as I said before, with all the college bands you would see — occasionally you would see a baritone player, a woman baritone player. But it's changed a lot and it's really changed for the better. And I think we're seeing a lot of — there's some really good — what's her name, Carrington, the good drummer, you know the good girl drummers. There used to be — well there was Shirley Scott who was this very good organ player who established herself. Dorothy Ashby, a fine harpist, but she didn't live long enough to really —

MR: What about race, racial issues in jazz now?

DM: Now — I think it's pretty good now from what I can see. We went through some ups and downs. I was with *DownBeat* during a relatively interesting time as in the Chinese saying "may you live in interesting times." There was a lot going on. You know there was a phenomenon which is very understandable and logical and was bound to happen sooner or later. In spite of the fact that jazz was one area where there were really good relations between the races, there was a residue of built-up and, you know, resentment among black musicians that they were unable to get the best jobs in the studios, that they were exposed to things like separate union locals where the scale for blacks was lower than for whites. You know that was an extraordinary circumstance. Local 802 in New York was never like that. That was always integrated. But even in a progressive city like Chicago you had two union locals and different scales. And, you know, many things like that. So that was kind of pent-up and it came out in the sixties and seventies in conjunction with all the civil rights activity then; the much more outspoken role that was taken on by blacks and it was bound to reflect itself in music too. So that, then you had some overtones of a little bit of strife there. And the magazine had inherited Amiri Baraka who was then still Leroi Jones, from Don DeMichael, who had very courageously engaged him as a columnist in spite of the publisher's apprehension, and let him say what he wanted to say. And there was readers' reaction from that and it was interesting, and it was something that was the right thing to do. So there was Archie Schepp, who was somewhat of a provocateur, and at the same time one of his best buddies and on-call instrumentalists was Roswell Rudd. So I mean what tended to be the case I've found is that there was a lot of talk but when you look behind the talk there really wasn't that

there was — Newport in New York had, in the beginning, in their earlier years, they had some side events, panel discussions and stuff. And I was invited — this was just around the time when I was leaving *DownBeat* because I had real problems with the publisher, who was the son of the original publisher, old man Maher, who had his quirks but I was able to get along with him and you knew where he was coming from. His son was really somebody who came in without having any experience with or knowledge of jazz other than what he had absorbed from the family. And he and his father didn't get along at all so it was a shortcut there too. But I just had to leave the magazine. It was right in the middle of that, which of course nobody outside was really aware of other than people close to me, and I was asked to be on this panel. I think it was called "The Drum" or something or other. It turned out that I was the only white person along with about five guys who were — some of them were educators — I didn't even know most of them — and Max Roach, who was the moderator. And some of the people on there were very much to the left. And I was raked over the coals, not only as representing *DownBeat*, that's one thing, but then it also became — you know there were racial matters that came into it. And I finally said something about, you know, I'd had enough of this. And it wasn't easy. And in the audience there were also some people who chimed in on that. There were actually some people in Newark, where I hadn't been yet because it was before — I wasn't with the Institute yet. Anyway, I finally made a little speech and I walked out, and walked off. But that was after some considerable time. So anyway, the first person to come out and join me in the hallway was Martin Williams, you know, we were friends and he hugged me and he said — but then when it was over, I still — I didn't go away, I stayed. I think there was something going on after that that I wanted to attend. And then Max came out. And Max and I were old acquaintances. I wouldn't say that we were close friends but we were certainly well acquainted. And then Max came over and he actually gave me a hug too and then he said something interesting, he said, "You have to understand," he said, "this wasn't personal." He said, "This is something that we have to go through."

MR: I see. Do you think those musicians who were playing, I mean Archie Schepp's music, just to use his name with that genre, this is music that's let's say challenging for the average listener. Do you think that they honestly thought that if they got the right amount of exposure in magazines and the media that they could sell more records?

DM: Yes, absolutely. I mean Archie, who is a very clever fellow and very sophisticated, was perfectly aware that doing things, writing, expressing himself verbally and doing things that were to some extent deliberately provocative, that that should result in people wanting to check out his music and also that he might enlist people who were politically

garde in jazz was very publicity-conscious. They were very much aware of the fact that if they were making provocative statements and all these things — and the music itself of course was aggressive, some of it. Interestingly enough, I mean Ornette's music was never — Ornette very rarely, although he sometimes said things — he usually had to do with recognition of his music rather than putting it on a more universal social-political platform. It was always very personal with Ornette. And Ornette's music was a thing unto itself. But it was a very interesting period. And there was the attempt with the "Jazz and People's Movement" to get exposure on television, which was perfectly reasonable. You know jazz was never sufficiently well exposed on T.V. But the way they went about it, and what they eventually managed to accomplish, was counterproductive. I mean that was — I was closely involved in that because we had controversies in the pages of *DownBeat*. But they went on the Cavett show. They picketed these various television shows. Merv Griffin, Cavett, and Ed Sullivan. And on Cavett, because Cavett was always — you know he was a very verbal guy, so he put musicians on a panel and talked to them and there was Andy Cyrille and Freddie Hubbard and Cecil Taylor. And my God, you know that discussion was totally — it would not have appealed to anyone who didn't have some really inside knowledge of the music and it was off-putting, because it was simply — it addressed issues that the average listener had nothing to do with. And then they also said stupid things. Like Freddie, whom I was very fond of and who, poor guy, I mean what he went through and he messed up his embouchure and it was embarrassing to see him trying to play and then the poor guy died you know. But that was a long time ago. He was young and brash and everything. Well he said, notably, one totally off the wall thing, he said that Coleman Hawkins was wrapping packages in Queens. Coleman Hawkins first of all never went near Queens, and secondly he had — although his health was declining he had a beautiful apartment in Central Park West, he had a Chrysler Imperial parked — it was rusting because he wasn't using it, but God knows — so this was really dumb stuff. And then they got on Sullivan and gave them a closing five minutes. Do you remember that?

MR: I did not see that.

DM: Well there were a bunch of people who were involved in this who were not necessarily on this same page musically. But they put together an ad hoc band that included Mingus, Archie, Rahsann and I forget who the drummer was, somebody else. And what they played was — even for somebody like me who is familiar with what was then called avante garde jazz — it was a total mess. And for anything, to try to appeal to the broad mass of listeners. It's just — they should have played a tune. They played a song that people were familiar with, God, it wouldn't have been anything that they had to be

out there. So the whole thing was a total flop. And it was childish. And later on Andy, who is still very much around — so is Archie but I hardly ever see him, he isn't playing anymore. He had trouble with his embouchure too. But Andy has been to the Institute quite a few times and we've become friendly. That's all over, all that stuff. And Rahsann, who was a really — you know he was a terrific person but he was being used by these people. Well anyway that's all over, that's long — water under the bridge and we don't really have any of that stuff going on anymore. But there are still occasions when something will come up and there are still people who feel that – until this day -- there are things that are wrong in the so-called music business and that black artists are still being taken advantage of and that they're still — and it comes up once in a while.

MR: Well we have just a couple of minutes left and I — recently there was a fellow who wrote in the Jazz Educators Network about the — he called it the "paradox of the jazz scene" and that jazz is now taught in almost every university and Jazz at Lincoln Center, and all the high schools and the whole thing, yet record sales are very small and even the musicians who play the music, the young people, don't buy things that much anymore. Do you have any observations on the current state?

DM: Well the whole phenomenon of jazz education is of course a very interesting one because as the music became less popular, less visible, jazz education boomed and there are hundreds of places where you can take courses in jazz. I think it's very useful because most of the people that learn to play an instrument and learn to play jazz, one of the things that will stay with them and maybe for a lifetime is the fact that they can have the pleasure of playing for their own enjoyment with other people. Making a profession out of it is sometimes difficult. Yet there are people, for instance institutions like Berklee, have produced a lot of musicians who have become first class prominent professionals. But it's something — it's also I guess it has become a way for many — I wouldn't say failed musicians, but musicians who have been unable for one reason or another to have profitable playing careers to become teachers. And many of them are very good, very able, and it's provided also an income for really good players who couldn't really make a good living playing anymore. But what you said about record sales, the industry promoted percentages have always been way off the mark because the record industry association, RIAA, is purely interested in major label products. They have never included anything from really small independent labels. They have never included jazz imports in their statistics. So when they say jazz sales only represents three percent that was always nonsense because all you had to do was — in the good old days — when there were record stores like Tower, if you walked into a Tower store why would they give so much space to jazz if it wasn't selling more than three percent? That wouldn't have made any

questionable. But nowadays of course most jazz record sales are off statistics altogether because it's musicians selling their CDs when they go out and perform. I mean that's where you find most of what you see today. You go to a concert, at least that's the case in New York, there's a table there in front before you enter the hall there, there's a table manned by a couple of people and there are stacks of CDs that represent the performer. And when you go out on the road, I know people who are friends of mine, they pack, they've got CDs in their car, you know, they've got boxes of CDs. That's where the sales are. And they don't enter the official statistics. It's just like it's said that CDs are vanishing. They're not. I mean it's true in the classical field too, the same thing happens there. So there is a lot of stuff still around but it's off the beaten marketing path. And so I think people will continue to want to own a tangible item of something that they can play for their friends or whatever. You know all the other stuff that you can hear on your headphones and your earbuds, you know, it's out in cyberspace. And I think there is a proprietary instinct in people. It's the same thing with books. You know e-books and all that, it's fine, but you still want to have — and also you want to be able to, you know your friends come to visit and they see all the books.

MR: That's a good point. Self promotion. Well we have an appointment with Amtrak, so I want to thank you for your time today.

DM: Well I've really enjoyed my visit to Hamilton. I always wanted to come here. And you've got a really lovely spot here and I hope that I may be back someday. And it's great that you also have all these live performances here.

MR: That's what it's all about. All right. Thanks for your time.